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Things you need to know about Orlando

When people think of Orlando, most think of theme parks and a vast urban sprawl. However, the city proper contains none of the major theme parks (Disney World, Universal Studios, Sea World), dinner attractions (Arabian Nights, Medieval Times), or even most small theme parks (Gatorland, Holyland Experience, Ripley's Believe-it-or-not, etc.). However, since Orlando is the larger city associated with most of these popular attractions, you will find details and descriptions of them below.



Climate

Most tourists visit Orlando between June and August, while another peak time for tourism is March and April. Ironically, the less busy times for tourism correspond to the best weather in the Orlando area; the summer months can be exceptionally busy with families who are making a trip while kids are on summer vacation. Visiting when the weather isn't so hot means less people in the area and that provides some advantages, but you will be able to enjoy cooler weather.

Many say central Florida has two seasons: hot and hotter. Orlando has warm,

Climate	Jan	Feb	Mar	Apr	May	Jun	Jul	Aug	Sep	Oct	Nov	Dec
Daily highs (°F)	72	73	77	83	88	91	93	93	89	84	77	73
Nightly lows (°F)	50	51	55	61	67	73	75	73	72	65	56	51

Precipitation (in)	2.1	3.1	3.5	2.6	3.0	6.5	8.1	7.5	6.8	3.9	1.7	2.1

balmy springs and autumns; hot summers complete with daily thunderstorms; and temperate winters affected by the occasional cold front. That being said:

- **Spring** in Orlando has highs in the 80s (27°C) in March & April transitioning to around 90°F (32°C) in May and low-mid 90s in June. Spring is the driest time of year here, and in the past decade some spring months have seen less than a half-inch of rain! This is the time of year in which many small wildfires appear around the region, but this should not bother anyone who stays within the urban area. March and April are great times to visit with dry days, clear skies, and warm temperatures (and no cold fronts). However, late May and early June are arguably the worst time to visit filled with hot, humid, dry days.

- **Summer** begins with the start of daily thunderstorms around mid-June. Highs from mid-June to mid-September are in the mid 90s, with 90°F (32°C) often being reached by 10-11AM, and lows in the 70s (23°C). Due to Orlando's proximity to two coasts, thunderstorms form everyday during this period from ocean breezes which heat over land, rise, and cool in the atmosphere to create sometimes violent thunderstorms (see the "Stay Safe" section). However, they often will drop temperatures into the low 80s (28°C) after passing…a welcome relief from the hot temperatures earlier in the year.

- **Autumn** varies much more from year to year than spring. The daily thunderstorms taper

Florida Cold & Snow

While most think of Florida as a year-round paradise, many would be surprised to learn that there are at least ten clear winter mornings a year when lows fall to near freezing. However, even on the coldest of mornings, highs will soon reach into the 50s and 60s! Nevertheless, every 3-4 years, snow flurries will mix with rain somewhere in the region, the most recent being a snow/sleet mix on an exceptionally cold 9 January 2010. However, only once since records began in 1948 has any measurable snow fall at the airport (0.2" in/0.5 cm Jan 1977). So if you visit between November and March, bring a jacket…it may be

warmer than northern states, but not as warm as you may think it will be!

off in September leaving highs in the mid-high 80s (29°C) until mid-October. The first cold front of the season will usually pass between mid and late October, plunging highs into the 70s (24°C) and lows into the 50s (12°C) and high 40s (10°C). The cooling trend continues into November and December, with highs falling into the 70s (24°C) by late December and lows into the 50s (12°C), affected only by the occasional cold front which can plunge highs into the 60s (18°C)(Nov) and 50s (12°C)(Dec) and lows into the 40s (7°C)(Nov) and as low as freezing (32°F/0°C) by mid December.

- **Winter** is much the same as November and December. Highs are in the 70s (24°C), lows in the 50s (12°C), affected every week or two by cold fronts. Following a cold front, highs can drop into the 50s (12°C), lows into the 30s (2°C). Sub-freezing mornings typically occur two or three times a year.

Getting to Orlando in a nutshell

By plane

Orlando International Airport

Orlando International Airport (IATA: **MCO**) is the city's primary airport, and the second busiest airport in the state in terms of passenger traffic. The airport is located to the southeast of downtown but is conveniently located with respect to the region and area attractions. Orlando International Airport is a focus city (or minor hub) for Frontier Airlines (serving about 10-12 cities), JetBlue Airways (20-25 cities), & Southwest Airlines (40-45 cities), all of which fly numerous routes to/from Orlando. Furthermore, Delta Air Lines offers 10-15 1.5-hour flights daily between Orlando and their mega-hub in Atlanta and American Airlines has around 10 45—minute flights a day to their Miami hub. Non-stop service is offered to nearly every major city east of the Mississippi and to several major western cities (LA, San Francisco, Seattle, Phoenix, Las Vegas, Salt Lake City, & Denver). With Orlando's status as a major vacation destination, most airlines fly to Orlando from nearly all of their hubs (and with multiple daily flights from hubs east of the Mississippi River). The busiest domestic routes (Aug 2011-Jul 2012) from Orlando are Atlanta (1.3 million passengers on Delta or Southwest/AirTran), New York-JFK (700,000 passengers on American, Delta, & JetBlue), Philadelphia, Newark, Detroit, Miami, Dallas/Fort Worth, Charlotte, Chicago-O'Hare, & Baltimore.



Daily flights to Europe are offered by Virgin Atlantic (London-Gatwick & Manchester), British Airways (London-Gatwick), & Lufthansa (Frankfurt). Multiple flights per week are flown to Dublin (Aer Lingus) and Glasgow (Virgin Atlantic, seasonally). To South America, there are daily flights to Rio de Janeiro-Galeão (TAM), São Paulo-Guarulhos (twice daily on TAM; seasonally on Whitejets), & Bogota (Avianca, Jet Blue) and seasonal service to Santiago, Chile (LAN). Over a dozen Canadian destinations are served non-stop, many seasonally. Calgary, Montreal, & Toronto are served year-round. Edmonton, Halifax, Hamilton, London, Moncton, Ottawa, Quebec, Saint John's, & Winnipeg are served seasonally. Destinations in the Caribbean and Central America are: Aruba (Southwest); Cancún, Mexico (JetBlue); Kingston, Jamaica (Carri bean); Marsh Harbour, the Bahamas (United); Mexico City (AeroMexico, Volaris); Montego Bay, Jamaica (JetBlue, Southwest); Monterrey, Mexico (VivaAerobus, seasonally); Nassau, the Bahamas (Bahamasair, JetBlue); Panama City (Copa); Port of Spain, Trinidad and Tobago (Caribbean); San Jose, Costa Rica (JetBlue); San Salvador, El Salvador (Taca); & Santo Domingo, Dominican Republic (JetBlue). The airport was approved in 2012 to operate flights to Cuba. Orlando International regularly sees

Boeing 747s from Virgin, British Airways, & Lufhansa; however, and despite being one of the first prepared to handle it, there has yet to be an A380 seen on routes to/from MCO.

Orlando International is structured into two components, landside and airside. There is a central landside terminal (one building divided into sides “A” and “B”), containing airline counters, baggage claim, rental agencies, numerous shops, and a hotel. This central terminal is connected via trams to four other terminals, known as Airside 1-4, with the airplane gates. There are plenty of shops and restaurants in both the central terminal and the airsides.

Security screening is performed in the central landside terminal before taking the tram to the airsides and, as in all U.S. airports, only ticketed passengers are allowed past security. Security lines can become extremely long (1 hr), especially during the summer tourist season and near holidays. Combined with long check-in lines, it is advisable to arrive 2-3 hours before your scheduled departure.

Orlando is the “rental car capital of the world” and, as can be expected, there are many **car rental agencies** offering a large number and wide range of vehicles for rental. Additionally, there are numerous car rental agencies located off-site which provide free airport transfers from their location and may offer lower prices (See OIA website). Rental agencies at the airport are: Advantage Rent A Car (1 407-857-1999), Alamo (1 800-327-9633), Avis (1 800-831-2847), Budget (1 800-527-0700), Dollar Car Rental (Domestic: 1 800-800-4000, International: +1 800-800-6000), Enterprise Rent-A-Car (1 800-325-8007), E-Z Rent A Car (1 800-277-5171), Hertz Car Rental (1 800-654-3131), L and M Car Rental (1 407-888-0515), National (1 800-227-7368), Thrifty (+1 800-367-2277). **Beware:** Several gas stations near the airport prey on visitors topping off the tanks of rental cars by charging extraordinarily high prices ($2-3/gallon above local prices)! The practice has made national news and all stations are now required to display their prices on road-side displays. Nonetheless, there are still many unsuspecting visitors who are shocked to pull up to a gas pump with regular unleaded gas for $6.50/gallon, when stations 2-3 miles away are charging just $3.50!!

Public transportation in the Orlando area is provided by **Lynx** (+1 407-841-5969) bus system. Lynx buses can be found on the Ground Transportation Level (Level 1) of the Main Terminal's "A" side at Commercial Lane spaces A38-A41. Fares are $2/ride with free transfers within 90 minutes. Day passes are $4.50 and a 7-day pass costs $16. Discounted fares for Youth/Elderly requires riders to present a Lynx-issued ID, available only by applying at the Central Station Terminal with a 5-7 day turnaround and therefore not viable for short-term visitors. Routes (known as *links*) from the airport are:

- Link 11—Downtown Orlando (Map/Schedule; departures every 40 minutes between 6AM-midnight M-F, 6AM-10PM Sa, & 6:30AM-9:30PM Su/holidays).
- Link 41—Apopka (Map/Schedule; departures between 5:15AM-22:45PM M-Sa & 5:30AM-21:30PM Su/holidays).
- Link 42—International Drive (Map/Schedule; departures every 60 minutes between 5:30AM-11:30PM M-Sa, 6:30AM-11PM Su/holidays).
- Link 51—Downtown Orlando (Map/Schedule; departures every 40 minutes between 5:30AM-10:30PM M-Sa, 5:15AM-9PM Su/holidays).
- Link 111—Walt Disney World (Map/Schedule; departures every 75 minutes between 5AM-midnight daily/holidays).

Almost every medium to high priced hotel in the city offers **airport transfers**. Additionally, there are several **shuttle services** options that run from the airport to various points, including Kissimmee, theme parks, University of Central Florida, and the cruise port at Port Canaveral. Approximate rates for shuttle vans range from $18-26 depending on your destination (see OIA website for details on local transport). You may wish to contact your hotel to inquire about discounts on certain shuttles or possibly free airport transfers.

- **Disney's Magical Express**, ☎ +1 407 939-6244. Complimentary shuttle and luggage delivery service for guests staying at a Walt Disney World Resort hotel. Advance reservations are required.

- **Mears Transportation**, ☎ +1 407 423-5566. Provides shuttle service from Orlando International to many hotels in and around the region, including those in the Disney area that are not served by Magical Express.
- **InterPlex Transportation – Orlando**, toll-free: +1-888-398-5392. Provides limousine and car services from Orlando International Airport.
- **Orlando Airport Transportation**, ☎ +1 407-531-8565. Ground transportation and limo service from Orlando International Airport (MCO) to golf courses, hotels, hospitals, restaurants, attractions and many others.

Out-of-town shuttles provide service to destinations within about 1-2 hours' drive. These shuttles are prohibited from serving Orange, Seminole, and northern Osceola counties. A full, up-to-date list of these may be found on the OIA website.

Taxi Cabs/Vans may carry up to 9 passengers/luggage and may be found on the Ground Transportation Level (Level) of both the "A" and "B" sides of the Main Terminal. Rates are determined by a taximeter, regardless of the number of passengers, and flat fares are prohibited. Taxi Cab companies at the airport include: Ace Metro/Luxury Cab (1 407-855-1111); Diamond Cab Company (1 407-523-3333); Quick Cab (1 407-447-1444); Star Taxi (1 407-857-9999); Town & Country Transport (1 407-828-3035); & Yellow/City Cab (1 407-422-2222).

Located inside the landside terminal is the **Hyatt Regency**, ☎ 1 407-825-1234, fax: 1 407 856-1672, e-mail: orlan-reservations@hyatt.com.

Orlando-Sanford International Airport

A secondary airport which serves the Orlando area is the **Orlando-Sanford International Airport** (IATA: **SFB**) located in Sanford, a city just to the northeast of Orlando, the side of Orlando opposite most attractions. The airport is a hub for the small carrier Allegiant Air, which flies to smaller cities and secondary airports across the Eastern U.S & Canada.

The airport is owned by a European company and, as a result, has strong ties to European charter and holiday airlines. Service between Orlando Sanford International and Europe includes: Monarch Airlines (London-Gatwick & Manchester; seasonally to Belfast-International, Cardiff, Glasgow-International, & Newcastle upon Tyne); Thomas Cook Airlines (Manchester; seasonally to Belfast-International, Glasgow-International, & London-Gatwick); Thomson Airways (Birmingham, London-Gatwick, Manchester; seasonally to Bristol, East Midlands, Edinburgh, Glasgow, & Newcastle upon Tyne); Arkefly (Amsterdam); and Icelandair (Reykjavik, seasonal). Monarch, Thomas Cook, & Thomson flights can only be booked round-trip, originating in Europe; passengers cannot book outbound flights from Orlando-Sanford on these airlines.

Rental car agencies located on-site are: **Advantage**, ☎ 1 407 585-4445, toll-free: 1-800-777-5500">+1-800-777-5500.; **Alamo**, ☎ 1 407 585-3500, toll-free: 1-800-327-9633">+1-800-327-9633.; **Avis**, ☎ 1 407 585-4420, toll-free: 1-800-331-1212">+1-800-331-1212.; **Budget**, ☎ 1 407 585-4427, toll-free: 1-800-527-0700">+1-800-527-0700.; **Dollar**, ☎ 1 407 324-1314, toll-free: 1-800-423-4704">+1-800-423-4704.; **Enterprise**, ☎ 1 407 585-4400, toll-free: 1-800-736-8222">+1-800-736-8222.; **Hertz**, ☎ 1 407 585-4410, toll-free: 1-800-654-3131">+1-800-654-3131.; **National**, ☎ 1 407 585-4405, toll-free: 1-800-327-9633">+1-800-327-9633.; **Thrifty**, ☎ 1 407 324-1314, toll-free: 1-800-847-4389">+1-800-847-4389.

Taxi service is available from **Yellow Cab Company of Orlando**, ☎ 1 407 422-2222.. Shuttles are available from **American Coach Shuttle**, ☎ 1407322-1988">+1 407 322-1988, toll-free: 1-800-781-8999, e-mail: dsalter@horizoncoachlines.com. and **Orlando Carriers, Inc.**, ☎ 1407418-0513">+1 407 418-0513, e-mail: booking@orlandocarriers.com.

Regional airports

Other regional airports within an hour and a half drive include Daytona Beach International Airport (IATA: **DAB**; served by Delta to Atlanta and US Airways to Charlotte) & Melbourne International Airport (IATA: **MLB**; served by Delta to Atlanta,

US Airways to Charlotte, & Baer Air to Marsh Harbour, Bahamas). In addition, Orlando area visitors who plan on visiting the Gulf Coast may consider flying into Tampa International Airport (IATA: **TPA**), about 80 mi (130 km) west of Orlando or just over an hour's drive, as it is less crowded and a bit easier to access via road.

If you plan on visiting more than just Orlando and plan on taking international flights, you may want to consider flying via Miami International Airport, a 200 mi (320 km) and a 2-3 hour drive south of Orlando, which offers more international flights and is the largest U.S. gateway for flights to South/Central America & the Caribbean.

General aviation

All persons flying via general aviation should consider arriving via Orlando Executive Airport which is six miles east of downtown and about 10 or so miles (16 km) north of Orlando International Airport. Orlando Executive serves general aviation (95%) and air taxi (5%) exclusively. Additionally, Orlando Sanford International serves general aviation alongside its commercial use.

Orlando Executive Airport provides 24-hour service through two fixed based operators, SheltAir Aviation Services and Showalter Flying Services. Air taxi and air charter companies such as **Jetset Charter** fly a variety of private charter aircraft and jets, from charter luxury Gulfstream's down to economical piston twins for small groups and individuals.

By train



Orlando has an **Amtrak** station that provides service to other destinations such as Miami, but also connects to other points as far north as New York via the Silver Star and Silver Meteor lines.

In nearby Sanford, the southern terminus of the **Amtrak Auto Train** which carries passengers and automobiles between Sanford and Lorton, Virginia, effectively serving as a car-rail link from Orlando to the Washington, D.C. Metro Area.

By bus

- **ATC Buses**, 3916 Scotsboro Ct. Offers bus charter transportation to and from the Orlando Airport to Port Canaveral Cruises and hotels in the Orlando-Sanford area.
- **Greyhound**, 555 N John Young Pkwy. Visitors arriving by Greyhound can go south on SR-423 to I-4 to get to the major attractions.

- **Runways Transportation Company**, Orlando International Airport, Terminal A, Level 1, Spaces A15-A16. Runways offers daily intercity shuttle service to Gainesville, University of Florida, and Jacksonville International Airport.

- **Megabus**, 902 N Semoran Blvd (*northwest corner of Semoran Blvd and Colonial Dr*). Service from Atlanta, Jacksonville, Gainesville, Tampa, Fort Lauderdale, Miami, Tallahassee, Mobile, and New Orleans.

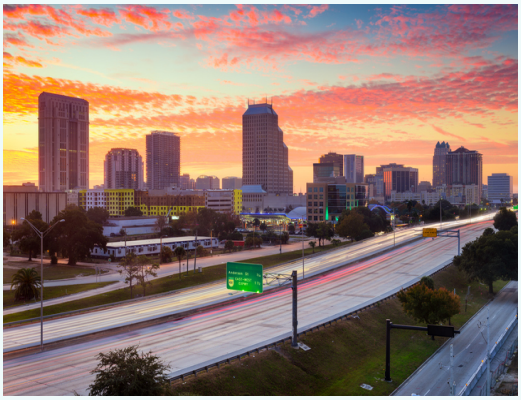
Fun ways of touring around in Orlando

By car

The car is omnipresent in Orlando, and it is a very easy and convenient (if not congested) way to get to your destination. Orlando is a sprawling city with most attractions lying far to the south of the CBD and into adjacent cities like Kissimmee. The roads are all wide and easy to drive on with all major attractions well signed, but traffic jams around downtown are common in the afternoons, and around the touristy areas on Friday nights and all day Saturday. Orlando ranks 8th in the nation in terms of traffic congestion, and there are numerous ongoing construction projects on area expressways. Traffic information is available from electronic signs over roadways, most local radio stations, and also by calling 511 (a free, automated service which provides current traffic info).

As with most urban areas in the U.S., there are plenty of drivers who prefer to speed and drive aggressively. The Orlando area receives over 50 million visitors each year, many who drive while in town, while home to just 2 million residents. The combination of these two types of drivers can make Orlando's roads a bit hectic at times. Speed limits in the Orlando area are higher than some parts of the U.S., with a speed limit of around 45-

Open Road Tolling



Open road tolling is employed along most of Orlando's toll roads. A driver with a SunPass or E-Pass transponder and a prepaid account continues straight along the road at the speed limit, with the toll accounted for electronically; drivers paying cash (almost all tourists) must follow signage that diverts them to toll booths constructed off the right side of the highway. Drivers who don't have transponders and continue going straight past the toll booth are photographed and ticketed. The fine is $100 per offense, plus tolls outstanding.

Some rental car agencies use Sunpass or toll-by-plate to cover tolls, with incurred tolls charged to the customer's credit card.

50mph on major roads. The speed limit on Interstate 4 and tollroads is 65mph, with urban sections close to downtown posted at 55mph. Drivers in the left lane tend to drive 5-15mph faster than the speed limit. While it is the law to keep right except to pass, this is not strictly enforced.

The main highway through Orlando, and the only interstate serving it, is **Interstate 4** (commonly called "I-4") which runs diagonally from northeast to southwest across the Orlando area. In recent years major construction on it has widened it through areas south of S.R. 528 making it a commuter-friendly highway (except for traffic during rush hours and Friday and Saturday evenings). Downtown Orlando; International Drive; Amway Arena; the Mall at Millenia; Arabian Nights dinner theater; and theme parks such as Walt Disney World, Universal Studios, Sea World, Discovery Cove, the Holy Land Experience, and Wet n' Wild are all conveniently located along/near I-4.

Inquire with the company when renting a car.

Toll roads in the Orlando area are **only** compatible with Florida's **SunPass** (or the older **E-Pass**) transponder for electronic payment. Other electronic tolling systems, including E-Zpass (Northeastern U.S.), TxTAG (Texas), and Fastrak (California), are **not compatible** with Sunpass.

If you mistakenly drive through a SunPass lane, you can still contact the Florida DoT to pay the toll without being fined; see sunpass.com/violationsMissedToll or contact +1-888-824-8655. You will need the license plate number and, to the best of your knowledge, note the date, time, and location of the missed toll.

Other major highways include the **Beach Line Expressway (S.R. 528)**, a toll road known until recently as the Bee Line, which runs east from I-4 (exit 72) towards the Space Coast beaches and Kennedy Space Center, Cocoa Beach, and Port Canaveral. S.R. 528 is, like all Orlando area *expressways* (which doesn't include I-4), a toll road. While tolls are modest for short trips within Orlando, tolls can quickly add on long cross-town trips. Bypassing Orlando on S.R. 417 is $5.50 for 55 mi (89 km). The **Central Florida GreeneWay (S.R. 417)** starts at I-4 just west of SR-192/Disney World. It takes you north, passing both the Orlando International Airport and the Orlando-Sanford International Airport. It ends at I-4 in Sanford, FL. **S.R. 408** starts at

SR-50 on the East side of Orlando, by the University of Central Florida and takes you past the west side of Orlando to the city of Ocoee, FL. It ends at the Florida Turnpike. **S.R. 429** starts in Apopka, FL at U.S. 441 and takes you past the Florida Turnpike and Disney World. It ends at I-4, just west of SR-192/Disney World. **Florida's Turnpike** starts in Miami, FL at I-95 and takes you north through Orlando and ends in Wildwood, FL at I-75. See this convenient toll calculator online: [7].

In Orlando, the main tourism area is **International Drive**, a strip of road that runs parallel to I-4 for about 10 miles (16 km). Many tourist-focused shops, restaurants, and attractions are to be found along this road; therefore, it is excruciatingly hard to drive on and find parking along this road on weekends, especially in the summer and from Thanksgiving to New Year's Day, and excursions to this area are best by bus during such times. Other major roads include: U.S. 192 in Kissimmee (fronted by thousands of small shops and attractions), Orange Blossom Trail (US 17/92/441…a North-South alternative to I-4), John Young Parkway (which can be an alternative to US-441), & S.R. 50 (E-W route towards the CBD).

A few local laws to keep in mind:

- **Lights on when raining**. It is the law in Florida to have headlights on when it is raining.
- **Seatbelt** use is mandatory.

- **Move over when passing stopped emergency vehicles**. Florida has a so-called "Move over" law, which compels drivers to move out of the lane closest to stopped emergency vehicles (police cars, ambulances, fire trucks). If it is not safe to do so, drivers must slow down **20 mph below** the speed limit to pass parked vehicles (this is higher than any other U.S. state with such a law, where it's normally 5-15 mph below the speed limit).

Gasoline

There are a few gas stations that prey on unsuspecting travelers returning rental cars to the airport. This includes Suncoast Energys and Sun Gas on Semoran Blvd near the airport entrance. Prices at these stations are often more than $2/gal above typical market price. Look before you pump! Plan ahead to have enough time before your flight to drive an extra mile or so up Semoran to the cheaper stations. There also are stations around Disney World that have similar practices.

By rental car

Orlando is the largest rental car market in the world and is known as capital of car rental companies, with all major car rental companies accessible. Operating directly within the airport are Alamo, Avis, Budget, Dollar, Enterprise, E-Z Rent-a-car, L & M Car Rental, National, and Thrifty; courtesy shuttles are available for transport to other rental companies.

If you arrive by air via Orlando International Airport and pick up a rental car there, you can go through the north exit and head to SR-528 West to get to International Drive, Universal Orlando and SeaWorld. This will require $1.75 in tolls. Alternatively, you can take a direct route to Walt Disney World through the south exit to SR-417 South, following it to Exit 5, and taking SR 536 straight into Disney. This requires $2 in tolls. Toll booths along this expressway uses open road tolling: see note above in box. Be careful when you return your rental car, the gas stations within 2 miles of the airport do not advertise their prices and cost over $5 per gallon. The prices 3 miles out are standard.

By bus

Orlando's public transportation is the LYNX bus service. Approximately 60 routes serve the metro Orlando area and costs $2 per ride (transfers included) except for the free Lymmo bus service downtown.

- **Lymmo Bus**, 1-841-LYNX. This free service operates frequently in a circuit in downtown, from City Hall to the Centroplex and back. The Lymmo has a dedicated

lane and stations with streetcar type control signals and modified buses that allow passengers to enter the bus without climbing. M-Th 6AM-10PM, F 6AM-midnight, Sa 10AM-midnight, Su 10AM-10PM.

LYNX buses of interest to visitors include routes 8, 42, 50, and 111 — e.g., bus 8 or 42 for Universal, bus 8 for SeaWorld, and bus 50 or 111 for Disney. Seven-day standard passes are $16. Check out GO LYNX to plan your trips.

By train

- **SunRail**, +1-855-RAIL-411 (7245-411). It is limited to a north-south route through the center of the area, with an initial southern end at Sand Lake Road, and northern end in DeBary. Bus connection is provided from Orlando International Airport to the Sand Lake Road station by Links 11, 42 and 111; and from Orlando-Sanford International Airport to the Sanford station by Link 46E.

Base one-way fare is $2.00, with an addition of $1.00 for each county line crossed. An all-day pass costs $4.50.

Direct rail connections to OIA and the attractions areas are currently being studied for possible future expansion.

There is currently no service on weekends and some federal holidays.

By trolley

- **I-Ride Trolley**, *+1* 407-248-9590. Along International Drive and Universal Blvd, this trolley primarily serves tourists in the attractions area, operating daily from 8AM to 10:30PM. While the service is advertised as a trolley, the trolleys are in fact modified buses traveling in traffic with many stops, which makes for a slow ride. There are 85 stops along the main (Red) route on International Drive and 22 stops on the (Green) route that serves less congested Universal Blvd. The fare is $1.25 per ride for adults, 25¢ for seniors, and free to kids younger than 12; exact

change is required. There's an unlimited 1-day pass available for $4 per person. One-day and multi-day passes, not sold on the bus, are available in many locations. However, because of the very limited route coverage of I-Ride –- it goes nowhere near Disney — the better choice for many visitors is to use LYNX buses (e.g., bus 8, 42, 50, or 111).

By taxi

Orlando is visited by millions of tourists each year and there are dozens of taxi companies that are operational in the region. It will not be a problem to find transportation from The Orlando Airport to your hotel or from the hotel to a theme park, restaurant or mall. Unfortunately, some of those companies do not have any license or insurance, and operate illegally. If you are not planning to rent a car, you probably should do some research and arrange your transportation before arriving to Orlando.

Stunning places to see and visit in Orlando

Gardens & Parks



- **Arboretum, University of Central Florida**, 4000 Central Florida Blvd, ☎ +1 407 823-3146. An arboretum and botanical garden covering 80 acres (32 hectares), containing more than 600 species of plants (including more than 100 bromeliads) in cultivated gardens. Its cultivated areas currently include a Conservatory Compound, a Bromeliad Sanctuary, Cycad Garden, Fern Garden, Palm Collection, Rose Garden, Swamp Habitat, and Wetland Plants Display. Free.

- **Harry P. Leu Gardens**, 1920 N Forest Ave, ☎ +1 407 246-2620. Beautiful landscaped gardens and lakes set in nearly 50 acres of land, featuring flora gathered from around the globe since 1936, including the largest rose garden in Florida and America's largest camellia collection outside of California. The Leu House, Harry P. Leu's former home set within the grounds and dating back to the 1880's, has tours every 30 minutes around its museum illustrating Florida living at the turn of the 20th century (closed during July). You can get married in various places in the gardens and there are special events held throughout the year. 9AM-

5PM daily except Christmas Day. Last garden admission at 4PM. Admission $7 (free Mondays, 9AM-noon).

- **Historic Bok Sanctuary**, 1151 Tower Blvd, ☎ +1 863 676-1408. Lake Wales. The Bok Sanctuary features acres of intricately landscaped gardens filled with an exotic array of flowers and trees. The gardens are home to a colony of wood ducks and many other wild birds. In the middle of the gardens sits the Bok Tower, with its 60-bell carillon playing music daily at 3PM. 8AM-6PM daily with last admission at 5PM. Visitor Center 9AM-5PM daily. Admission $10.

- **Torii Shinto**, College Park, ☎ +1 407-484-6099. Torii Shinto is a private tropical garden. To visit the garden you must make an appointment as the garden is a private residence that is open to garden club tours, wedding and commitment ceremonies and for private tours to enthusiasts of horticulture. The garden hosts rare palms, bromeliads, heliconias, orchids and thousands of other plants from around the world. The species you will discover in this garden include: Carpoxylon Palm or Aneityum Palm – Carpoxylon macrospermum, Tahina spectabilis (discovered in Madagascar in 2007, described in 2008) thus this Tahina is a small specimen seedling (about 3'), Flame Thrower Palm – Chambeyronia macrocarpa, White Elephant Palm, King Thai Palm – Kerriodoxa elegans, Foxy Lady Palm – Wodyetia X Veitchia bifurcatum x arecina to name a few. Hercules, a 21.5' diameter Live Oak provides protection from the few cold days that Orlando hosts, Hercules is listed at the ninth largest Live Oak in Florida on the Live Oak Society registry. The garden hosts a view to a bald eagle nest in a neighboring pine. The garden is divided into several outdoor rooms with fountains, hand carved Bali lanterns and hand carved volcanic stone statuary. The owner is a landscape architect and indicates that tours for plant enthusiasts are always welcome. Free/Donation.

- **A World of Orchids**, 2501 Old Lake Wilson Rd. Kissimmee. *Closed since mid-2012. Do not believe the large signs on the highway.*

Museums

- **Charles Hosmer Morse Museum of American Art** — Houses the world's most comprehensive collection of the works of Louis Comfort Tiffany (1848-1933) including Tiffany art glass, leaded-glass windows, lamps, jewelry, pottery, paintings, and the chapel interior he designed for the 1893 World's Columbian Exposition in Chicago. The Museum's holdings include a major collection of American art pottery and representative collections of late-nineteenth and early-twentieth century American paintings, graphics, and decorative arts. $3 adults, $1 students, and free for children under 12. Free between 4PM-8PM Nov-Apr each F.



Cornell Fine Arts Museum, 1000 Holt Ave, ☎ +1 407 646-2526. Tu-F 10AM-4PM, Sa Su noon-5PM. Winter Park. Rollins College. Features items from Cornell's renowned permanent collection. $5.

- **The Orlando Museum of Art**. Ongoing exhibitions of American portraits and landscapes, American impressionist works, and art of the ancient Americas.

- **The Orlando Science Center**. A 207,000 ft² (19,000 m²) hands-on learning center with hundreds of interactive exhibits for visitors of all ages. Images surround visitors on the giant screen of the Dr. Phillips CineDome. Other attractions include the Body Zone, teaching health and fitness, as well as an observatory. The center has the largest refracting telescope in Florida.

- **Orange County Regional History Center**, 65 E Central Blvd, ☎ 1 407 836-8500, toll-free: 1-800-965-2030">+1-800-965-2030. M-Sa 10AM-5PM, Su noon-

5PM. Features exhibits and artifacts from the earliest days of the region to the modern day. Includes information on everything from the time of the Seminole Indians to the founding of the city to the Civil Rights era to the Disney period to today. $9-12.

- **International Trolley and Train Museum** — Features 14 model railroad trains with sound and lighting traveling through an indoor garden with 12 ft (4 m) high mountains, waterfalls, and more than 30 trestles and tunnels. Also on display are toy trains from the 1920s to the present. Visitors can catch a ride in a California Victorian-style half open/half closed trolley or the 5/8-scale replica of an 1880 locomotive (a Mason Bogey) with its passenger cars.

- **Ripley's Believe It or Not! Orlando Odditorium**, 8201 International Dr, ☎ +1 407-363-4418. Located in a building artfully constructed to appear as if it were collapsing to one side. Visitors can explore bizarre artifacts, strange collections, weird art/hobbies (for example, check out the 3/4-scale model of a 1907 Rolls Royce Silver Ghost automobile made entirely of matchsticks and glue), and interactive exhibits in sixteen odd galleries. Seriously schlocky, yet fun.

Cool things to do in Orlando

Orlando, a city in central Florida, is home to more than a dozen theme parks. You'd find Orlando's got a lot more to offer than just Mickey!



- **Revolution: The Off Road Experience**. Offers 4-wheeling, 4×4, dune buggying and more.
- **Enzian Theater**. A cinema for the indie/alternative crowd that also offers food and alcoholic beverages.
- **Discovery Cove**. A 30-acre tropical retreat with beaches, snorkeling and relaxation.

Major Attractions

Orlando is one of the biggest tourist destinations because of the nearby theme parks and resorts. Close to International Drive is **Universal Orlando Resort**, which includes two theme parks, three hotels and a large shopping district. **SeaWorld Orlando** is a marine theme park featuring Kraken, the biggest rollercoaster in the Orlando area, as well as Believe, the new Shamu adventure. About 35 minutes southwest of downtown Orlando is Walt Disney World. Comprising four theme parks, two water parks, dozens of hotels, two shopping and dining districts, five golf courses, and much more, it is the largest privately managed tourist destination on the planet. Not far from Disney World lies the Alligator Capital of the World: **Gatorland.**

- **Walt Disney World** (*18 mi S of downtown in Lake Buena Vista*). The acclaimed gold standard of theme parks on the planet. Hours vary by park and season.

- **Universal Orlando Resort**, International Dr, ☎ +1 407 363-8000. 9AM-closing times varying from 6PM-10PM. Top-ranked challenger to Disney, with two theme parks — the original *Universal Studios Florida* and the second theme park, *Islands of Adventure* — a nightclub and restaurant complex, *CityWalk*, and three resort hotels. Discounts are given for purchasing tickets online.

- **SeaWorld Adventure Park Orlando**, SeaWorld Dr, ☎ 1 407 351-3600, toll-free: 1-800-327-2424">+1-800-327-2424. 9AM-closing times varying from 6PM-10PM. A beautifully landscaped 200-acre marine theme park featuring fantastic shows, thrilling rides, and fun exhibits — a more laid-back alternative to Disney and Universal. Variety of discounts may be available by purchasing tickets online.



- **Aquatica**, 5800 Water Play Way. Hours vary by season. Opened in 2008 water park by Sea World.
- **Discovery Cove**, 6000 Discovery Cove Way (*9AM-5:30PM (until 9PM on selected evenings)*), ☎ +1 407 370-1280. A unique companion to Sea World, it is often sold out as admission is limited to 1000 guests per day but admission does include **all** your equipment, food, drink and 30-minute interaction with the dolphins in the water. $259-279, $159-179 for non-dolphin package.
- **Holy Land**, 4655 Vineland Rd. Closed Tu. Either inspirational or kitschy, depending on your proclivities, this biblical-themed park is designed to look like Jerusalem. Discount on tickets purchased online.
- **Gatorland**, 14501 S Orange Blossom Trl, ☎ 1 407 855-5496, toll-free: 1-800-393-5297">+1-800-393-JAWS (5297). 9AM-5PM daily. A small alligator and reptile themed park.

- **Wet 'N Wild**, 6200 International Dr, ☎ 1 407 351-1800, toll-free: 1-800-992-9453">+1-800-992-WILD (9453). Hours vary by season. Waterpark.

Minor Attractions

- **Basilica of Mary, Queen of the Universe**, 8300 Vineland Ave, ☎ +1 407 239-6600. This extravagant Catholic church has become a tourist attraction in itself, thanks in part to the millions of Catholics from around the world who visit it and the rest of Orlando every year. Note: It is not a parish and therefore it cannot perform weddings, funerals, or baptisms.

- **Florida EcoSafaris at Forever Florida (Zipline Safari)**, 4755 N Kenansville Rd, ☎ +1 407 957-9794, e-mail: info@floridaecosafaris.com. Reservations required. Journey deep into Forever Florida, a 4700 acre eco-ranch and wildlife conservation area, preserved just as nature intended. This beautiful site boasts 9 distinct Florida ecosystems and an endless array of natural flora and fauna including alligators, black bears, nearly two hundred species of birds and the endangered Florida panther. Choose your own fully-guided adventure: Coach Safari, Horseback Safari or, soar through the treetops on the Zipline Safari.

- **Orlando Watersports Complex**, 8615 Florida Rock Rd, ☎ +1 407 251-3100. A cable park for watersports. Offers lessons and two separate cable systems, a beginner and an advanced. A perfect way to experience Orlando's reputation as the watersport capital of the world.

Sports Teams

- **Orlando Magic** (*Amway Center*), 400 W Church St, ☎ +1 407 89-MAGIC (62442), e-mail: tickets@orlandomagic.com. Member of the National Basketball Association (NBA), the Magic is the city's only member of the big four.

- **Orlando Solar Bears** (*Amway Center*), 400 W Church St, ☎ +1 407 951-8200, e-mail: webmaster@orlandosolarbearshockey.com. Member of the East Coast

Hockey League (EHCL).

- **Orlando Predators** (*Amway Center*). Member of the Arena Football League (AFL).
- **Orlando City** (*Citrus Bowl*), toll-free: +1-855-ORL-CITY (675-2489). Professional soccer. Currently minor-league, will become a Major League Soccer (MLS) team in 2015.
- **UCF Knights**. The teams representing the University of Central Florida—with the largest undergraduate enrollment of any single university campus in the country—compete in NCAA Division I sports, currently as members of the American Athletic Conference. UCF has heavily invested in athletics facilities in recent years, with the most notable example being the football team's home of Bright House Networks Stadium.

Downtown

- **Downtown Orlando Information Center**, 201 S Orange Ave, ☎ +1 407-254-INFO (4636). Ste 102. Has two interactive kiosks and electronic message boards with information about local Downtown eateries, retailers, accommodations, special events, etc. M-F 9AM–6PM.

Despite the proximity of theme park haven Lake Buena Vista, the city has a lot to offer on its own. Downtown Orlando is a growing area centered around Orange Avenue that is packed with bars, clubs, and restaurants, as well as theaters and concert venues. The main strip on Orange Avenue is closed most nights because of the large volumes of pedestrians. Just a few blocks over is Lake Eola, a picturesque park situated around a swan-filled lake. In the middle of the lake is a lighted fountain that has been established as an icon of Orlando, and on one side of the lake stands the historic outdoor shell theater, where tourists and locals alike can see a version of the Nutcracker every December. Swan-shaped paddle boats are available for rental as well. Taking over for Church Street as the main night time hot spot is Wall Street. It is a small pedestrian only

alley off of Orange Avenue that houses several restaurants and bars. They also have frequent concerts on Wall Street, providing a stage for bands to play for everything from Cinco de Mayo to the Capital One Bowl and Citrus Bowl celebration weeks.

Golf

- **Bay Hill Club & Lodge**, 9000 Bay Hill Blvd, ☎ +1 407 876-2429. *Two courses:* 18 holes, over 7,205 yards with a par of 72 (Private Non-Equity); 9 holes, over 3,409 yards with a par of 36 (Private Non-Equity).
- **Boggy Creek Golf Club**, 3650 8th St, ☎ +1 407 857-0280. 9 holes, over 3,250 yards with a par of 36 (Public).
- **Country Club of Orlando**, 1601 Country Club Dr, ☎ +1 407 425-2319. 18 holes, over 6,591 yards with a par of 72 (Private Equity).
- **Cypress Creek Country Club**, 5353 Vineland Rd, ☎ +1 407 351-2187. 18 holes, over 7,014 yards with a par of 72 (Public).
- **Dubsdread Golf Course**, 549 West Par St, ☎ +1 407 246-2551. 18 holes, over 6,055 yards with a par of 72 (Municipal).
- **Eaglewood Golf Club**, 5800 Pga Blvd, ☎ +1 407 351-5121. 18 holes, over 2,516 yards with a par of 58 (Public).
- **EastWood Golf Club**, 13950 Golfway Blvd, ☎ +1 407 281-4653. 18 holes, over 7,176 yards with a par of 72 (Public).
- **Fairways Country Club**, 14205 E Colonial Dr, ☎ +1 407 282-7535. 18 holes, over 5,332 yards with a par of 70 (Public).
- **Faldo Golf Institute By Marriott**, 12001 Avenida Verde, *1* 888-463-2536. 9 holes, over 2,308 yards with a par of 32 (Public).

- **Ginn Reunion Golf Resort**, 1000 Reunion Way, toll-free: 1-888-418-9611">+1-888-418-9611. Reunion. 54 holes, 3 championship golf courses designed by Arnold Palmer, Jack Nicklaus and Tom Watson (Private).
- **Grand Cypress Resort**, 1 N Jacaranda St, toll-free: 1-800-835-7377. *Four courses:* 18 holes over 6,773 yards with a par of 72 (Public); 9 holes over 3,462 yards with a par of 36 (Public); 9 holes over 3,521 yards with a par of 36 (Public); 9 holes over 3,434 yards with a par of 36 (Public).
- **Grande Pines Golf Club**, 6351 International Golf Club Rd, toll-free: 1-800-371-1165">+1-800-371-1165. 18 holes, over 7,012 yards with a par of 72 (Public).
- **Lake Nona Golf Club**, 9801 Lake Nona Rd, ☎ 1 407 851-9091. 18 holes, over 7,011 yards with a par of 72 (Private Non-Equity).
- **Lake Orlando Golf Club**, 4224 Club House Rd, ☎ 1407298-1230">+1 407 298-1230. 18 holes, over 6,803 yards with a par of 72 (Public).
- **MetroWest Golf Club**, 2100 S Hiawassee Rd, ☎ 1 407 299-8800. 18 holes, over 7,051 yards with a par of 72 (Public).
- **Orange Tree Golf Club**, 7540 Woodgreen Dr, ☎ 1407351-2521">+1 407 351-2521. 18 holes, over 6,968 yards with a par of 71 (Private Non-Equity).
- **Rio Pinar Golf & Country Club**, 8600 El Prado Ave, ☎ 1 407 277-5121. 18 holes, over 6,929 yards with a par of 72 (Private Equity).
- **Ritz Carlton Golf Club**, 4048 Central Florida Pkwy, ☎ 1407393-4900">+1 407 393-4900. 18 holes, over 7,122 yards with a par of 72 (Public).
- **Shingle Creek Golf Club**, 9939 Universal Blvd, toll-free: 1-866-996-9933. 18 holes, over 7,213 yards with a par of 72 (Public).

- **Stoneybrook Golf Club**, 2900 Northampton Ave, ☎ 1407384-6888">+1 407 384-6888. 18 holes, over 6,820 yards with a par of 72 (Public).

- **Ventura Country Club**, 3333 Woodgate Blvd, ☎ +1 407 277-2640. 18 holes, over 5,467 yards with a par of 70 (Public).

Tennis

- **Orlando Tennis Center**, 649 W Livingston St, ☎ +1 407 246-2161.
- **Lake Cane Tennis Center**, 5108 Turkey Lake Rd, ☎ +1 407 254-9170.
- **Fort Gatlin Recreation Complex**, 2009 Lake Margaret Dr, ☎ +1 407 858-3290.

Venues

- **Orange County Convention Center** (*OCCC*), 9860 Universal Blvd, ☎ +1 407 685-1061. With 2.1 million-square feet of exhibition space, the OCCC serves as the area's convention and meeting center.

- **Universal Orlando Meetings & Events**, 1000 Universal Studios Plaza, toll-free: +1-888-266-2121. From 20 to 20,000 guests, a Universal event ensures that you will give your attendees something truly out of the ordinary.

World-class shopping malls in Orlando

Major malls



The Florida Mall — The largest mall in Orlando located at the crossroads of Orange Blossom Trail and Sand Lake Road, about a mile north of the Orange Blossom Trail/Florida Turnpike/Beachline Expressway interchange. Home to over 200 shops including Saks Fifth Avenue, Macy's, Dillard's, Nordstrom, JC Penney, and Sears. You can go an entire day in this mall and still not finish. Popular among international tourists wishing to stock up on cheap American goods, but of better quality than found at the many outlet malls/stores.

— This is Orlando's most upscale and beautiful mall. Find everything from Tiffany's to Hugo Boss and Gucci. Also home to upscale department stores like Macy's, Bloomingdales and Neiman Marcus. This also features Apple and Sony Style selling

computers and related products. This mall is part of the very new and trendy Millenia area of Orlando. Conroy Road exit off of I-4 a few miles south of downtown.

Orlando Fashion Square &mdash, E Colonial Dr and Macguire Blvd, more than a mile NE of downtown.

Outlet malls

Orlando Premium Outlets – Vineland Ave — Home to the biggest designers such as Armani, Fendi, Burberry, Ferragamo, Lacoste, Coach. Also home to Tommy Hilfiger, Nike, Polo, Nautica and many more. Located off of 535 and visible from I-4 closest to the Disney World area. This is the best mall to pick up bargains from all the name brands and designer wear.

Orlando Premium Outlets – International Drive (formerly Beltz/Prime Outlets) — Home to many designers such as Polo, DKNY, Nike, Reebok, and Liz Claiborne. The mall has completed a major renovation recently, resulting in a beautiful outdoor mall with a wide variety of stores.

Lake Buena Vista Factory Stores — Select from over 300 designer and name brands such as Gap, Reebok, Carters and Eddie Bauer. Stores offer factory direct, quality merchandise at savings up to 75%. Off of SR-535 near International Dr and Disney.

Ethnic enclaves

Little Saigon, East Colonial Dr (around N Mills). Here you will find Vietnamese and Asian grocery stores, gift shops, and a few herbal healing stores, which stock items from China, Vietnam, Hong Kong, etc. Also home to many good inexpensive Vietnamese and other Asian restaurants.

Little India area — This area is a bit spread out. You will find many Indian stores in the South Orange Blossom Trail area on the main streets and side roads. Starting with Lancaster Road, which houses a video store and Indian restaurant, and then traveling

south you will see a few Indian shops in clusters every mile all the way to 417 where you end at the local Indian movie theater.

Little Brazil, the north end of International Dr. Several Brazilian restaurants, bakeries, stores, hairdressers, imports and exports shops. Some are hiding on the back of strip malls, some others are easy to find right up front flying the Brazilian flag.

Try a bit of everything! What to eat in Orlando

A wide variety of restaurants can be found in **CityWalk** at Universal Orlando, including Margaritaville, Hard Rock Cafe, Pastamore, NASCAR Cafe and much more. Parking is $14 during the day and $3 after 6PM (except during holidays or special events, such as Halloween Horror Nights). Much choice can also be found in **Downtown Disney**, including Rainforest Cafe, Planet Hollywood, and Wolfgang Puck Cafe. Or, if you are rich, you can go to Texas de Brazil, a churrascaria, or Brazilian steakhouse.

Not a drop to drink?

Orlando's **tap water** is notorious among travelers for being unpalatable; many describe a sulfuric or metallic taste. Just as many find it perfectly drinkable, however, and it's absolutely as safe to drink as any other municipal water supply in the U.S. Either way, those who think they might be sensitive to Orlando's unique *terroir* should consider taking their refreshment from a bottle or can.

American



310 Lakeside. Classic American cuisine overlooking Lake Eola.

- **A Land Remembered**, 9939 Universal Blvd, ☎ +1 407 996-9939. A legendary Orlando steakhouse named after Patrick Smith's rich novel featuring Florida's historical moments and landscapes. Serving a variety of cuisine and accompanying wine list as succulent and filling as its namesake. Proudly serving Harris Ranch all Natural Prime Black Angus Beef, as well as menu items catering to all tastes.

- **Boston's Fish House**, 6860 Aloma Avenue, Winter Park, ☎ +1 407 678-2107. People drive from hours away to this charming family-owned restaurant that brings the fish and flavors of Boston to Orlando. Authentic New England Clam Chowder, Cod, steak tips and more. A hidden gem away from the hustle of all the theme parks, and worth the wait for a fresh meal made to order.

- **Bubbalou's Bodacious BBQ**, 3 locations. BBQ ribs, sandwiches and other smoked delights. Atmosphere has a home-style feel and plenty of pig companions.

- **Calypso Bar and Grill**, 6300 Parc Corniche Dr. Great menu with a Key West themed dining experience.

- **Everglades Restaurant**, 9840 International Dr, ☎ +1 407 996-9840. A one-of-a-kind gourmet dining experience featuring unique regional specialties, served in an enchanting setting dedicated to the Florida Everglades. Periodic Vine & Dine wine dinners featuring gourmet cuisine and fine wines.

- **Jack's Place**, 9700 International Dr, ☎ +1 407 996-9700. Tantalizing gourmet menu featuring prime steaks and fresh seafood in a whimsical atmosphere featuring the world's largest collection of autographed star caricatures.

- **Gabriel's Subs**, 2840 Curry Ford Rd. Excellent hot veggie subs.

- **Hamburger Mary's**. A gay-friendly burger joint with drag shows and drinks.

- **K Restaurant Wine Bar**. Upscale American dining.

- **Le Coq Au Vin**. A modern twist is given to classic French foods at this restaurant.

- **Kres Chophouse**. An upscale steak house located downtown.
- **Luma on Park**. American cuisine with an extensive wine list.
- **Norman's**, 4000 Central Florida Pkwy (*at Ritz-Carlton Grande Lakes*), ☎ +1 407 393-4333. Chef Norman Van Aken. Prix-fixe $55 and up.
- **Ponderosa**. An American steakhouse with a wide and varied buffet, from sausages to muffins all day. Great for those with a sweet tooth.
- **Raglan Road Irish Pub**, 1640 East Buena Vista Drive, Lake Buena Vista, ☎ +1 407 938-0300. Irish Pub at Downtown Disney. A fantastic menu with something for everyone, and great entertainment featuring live music and Irish Dancers. Reservations strongly recommended. $$.
- **Uncle Jones BBQ**, 1370 E Altamonte Dr, Altamonte Springs. Serving great potatoes, along with lima beans, BBQ pork, corn bread, fried okra, and Texas toast.
- **Urban Flats**. Flatbreads and wine are the centerpiece of this modern-casual restaurant and wine bar.

Peruvian

- **El Inka Grill Ceviche**, 4106 Town Center Blvd, ☎ +1 407 730-7979. El Inka Grill serves Peruvian seafood and other Peruvian food. Ceviche is their signature dish.

Asian flare

- **Funky Monkey Wine Company**. A restaurant featuring a variety of sushi and wine.

- **Garden Cafe**, 810 W Colonial Dr. Fantastic vegetarian (mostly vegan) Chinese food.

- **Khasiyat Indian Cuisine**, 852 W Lancaster Rd, ☎ +1 407 888-2147. Vegetarian/Indian cuisine.

- **Ming Court**. Nightly oriental folk music performances compliment a wide selection of sushi, dim sum and more.
- **Mr. Wong's Family Taste Chinese Cuisine**, 5076 W. Colonial Dr., ☎ +1 407-440-4609. Open lunch and dinner seven days a week. This restaurant is in the Chinatown shopping area on west Colonial Dr. It specializes in Chinese food. The sign reads in big red letters, "CHINESE CUISINE." Only when you see the menu is the whole name displayed. This is not a fancy place, but it serves excellent authentic Chinese food. The diner is given chopsticks, but silverware is readily available. A very clean place to eat. Reasonable pricing.
- **Tokyo Sushi & Grill**, 8111 Vineland Ave., ☎ +1 407 465-1188. 11:30 AM-10:30PM M-Sat; 12 noon to 10:30 PM Sun. Serves very good sushi and tempura. Offers other Asian dishes Moderate expense.
- **Sushi Tomi**, 8463 S. John Young Pkwy. (*In South Park Center*), ☎ +1 407-352-8635. 11:30 AM-2 PM and 5:30-9 PM daily. Japanese sushi and other Japanese food. Excellent quality. Moderately priced.
- **Pho Saigon Vietnamese & Thai Cuisine**, 5100 W. Colonial Drive (*Several doors east of 1st Oriental Market*), ☎ 1+407+253-7013FORMATNOCC. M-Th 9 AM-9PM; Fr-Sun 9 AM-10 PM. Serves mainly Vietnamese cuisine. Most food of excellent quality. Inexpensive prices.

Latin inspired

- **Cala Bella** (*Creek Beautiful*), 9939 Universal Blvd, ☎ +1 407 336-3393. Benvenuto! Cala Bella, Rosen Shingle Creek's upscale Italian Restaurant features Italian classics, with Mediterranean and American inspiration, accompanied by a diverse list of top quality wines.

- **Cuba Libre**. A Cuban restaurant that turns into a Latin dance club by night.
- **Garibaldi Mexican Restaurant**, 929 N Semoran Blvd. The best dishes are chili relleno and cheese enchilada.
- **Rolando's Cuban Restaurant**, 870 Semoran Blvd, Casselberry. Serves excellent rice, yucca, eggplant, plantains, and guava.
- **Rossi's Pizza**, 5919 S Orange Blossom Trl (*corner of Oak Ridge & Orange Blossom Trl*), ☎ +1 407 855-5755. Highly recommend the 12 inch thin-crust pepperoni pizza.
- **-Stefano's Trattoria**, 1425 Tuskawilla Rd, Winter Springs (*Red Bug and Tuskawilla*), ☎ +1 407 659-0101. Small, family-run, quiet (but still delicious) Italian/Sicilian restaurant five minutes out of Orlando. A local gem! (Best advice on dishes: Ask Stefano to personally make a recommendation, he walks around the restaurant and will tell you exactly what you want to eat!) $$.
- **Tony's Deli**, 1323 N Mills Ave. Best dishes: fava bean salad, hummus and the baklava.
- **Vito's Chop House**, 8633 International Dr, ☎ +1 407 354-2467. Great cooking and great wine. $15-30.

Turkish

- **Anatolia Orlando**, 8 7600 Dr Phillips Blvd, ☎ +1 407 352-6766. 11AM-10PM. Turkish, Mediterranean, Middle Eastern Cuisine with affordable prices. $10-20.

Drunk in love! What to drink in Orlando

Orlando nightlife away from the theme parks is centered mostly around **Central Boulevard** and **Orange Avenue** in downtown Orlando. Here you can walk and find many bars. A short walk away is the tiny **Thornton Park District**, located near the intersection of Washington and Summerlin. Among the dozens of cafes and pubs, you might stop in for a drink and a quick bite at **Dexter's** on Washington. For local flair head across the street to **Burton's Frosty Mug**, or sample the hip urban environment at the trendy **HUE** at the corner of Washington and Central.



Although most of the downtown Central avenue crowd is comprised of the "twentysomething" generation, for a more 30's and over entertainment experience, one can enjoy live jazz on many nights in the lounge of the **Grand Bohemian Hotel** located downtown on Orange Avenue. The jazz is excellent and the ambiance is quite comfortable, although drinks tend to be pretty pricey here.

Also, for a more professional crowd with a Latin twist, there is the **Samba Room**, located on Sand Lake Road, about 3/4 west of I-4. This is a lively restaurant and happy

hour type of place. The look is chic and the locals and tourists alike gather here for a quality food, beverage and people watching experience. You should ditch the shorts and flip-flops for a more casual chic look, but if you do you will be rewarded with a nice experience here. If you are traveling west on Sand Lake Road, after passing I-4, The Samba Room is on the left in a large shopping plaza. Latin food, music and mojitos are just some of the specialties here.

Across the street from the Samba Room, on Sand Lake Road, is the **Old Vines wine bar**, featuring live jazz usually from Thurs. through Saturday nights. The wine selection is extensive and the live jazz is some of the best in town. The jazz is performed in the front of the room by the entrance. There is a divider that separates the more intimate rear portion of the establishment, which is the main dining area.

There are quite a few places to enjoy quality dining and drinks along Park Avenue in Winter Park, an adjacent suburb which is just northeast of Orlando. Winter Park is known for its many older grande homes that dominate the more historic sections of this suburb affectionately referred to by many as the center of Orlando's "old money." Park Avenue is an active pedestrian street featuring trendy shoppes, galleries, restaurants and nightspots. It has recently grown from becoming a one street attraction to more of a district, as several nearby streets have now added similar attractions.

Of particular interest and uniqueness on Park Avenue is the **Wine Room**, a converted bank featuring literally hundreds of wines available for self serve sampling. The mode of purchasing here is to pre-load a wine "credit card" supplied by the Wine Room. You are then at liberty to peruse the entire building and select any wine you wish to try, merely by inserting your "credit card." Each wine station automatically deducts the value of your current purchase and advises you of your card balance. Dress is very casual here and you are likely to meet both locals and visitors, all sampling and enjoying their vinos of choice throughout the night.

At the theme parks, **CityWalk** at Universal Studios. For a nominal admission fee, both sites offer numerous venues for libations and entertainment. If you're staying along

International Drive, there are plenty of bars, pubs, and clubs.

- **Corona Cigar Company's Superstore & Cigar Bar**, 7792 West Sand Lake Rd, ☎ +1 407 248-1212. If you're interested in cigars and all the different kinds of cigars, then this place is for you. The Corona Cigar Company allows its customers to sample different cigars. They also serve drinks.
- **Howl At The Moon**, 8815 International Dr, ☎ +1 407 354-5999. Entertainers perform songs at request all night. A place where people can go to listen to music, dance, drink, and have fun.
- **Orena Sports Bar**, 6159 Westwood Blvd, ☎ +1 407 370-0303. Orena Sports Bar caters to both locals and tourists. The bar serves food and drinks. Visitors can go to eat, play games, watch sports games and more.
- **Velvet Bar at Hard Rock Hotel**, 5800 Universal Blvd, ☎ +1 407 503-3463. Sit down, relax and listen to music. Velvet Bar also has live bands.
- **Blue Martini**, 4200 Conroy Road Suite H246, ☎ +1 407 447-2583. Blue Martini is a very high end martini bar. People can enjoy live entertainment at the bar.
- **Dave & Buster's Inc.**, 8986 International Dr, ☎ +1 407 541-3306. Dave & Buster's is family friendly. Kids and adults can enjoy a great meal and play a variety of games. There is also a bar for the adults where they can sit, order drinks, and watch a sports game.

Great places to stay in Orlando

With a hotel around virtually every corner (actually 4 or 5 around every corner) it seems impossible to throw a rock and not hit a hotel. There are hotels to meet every traveler's need, whether it be a hostel or a 5-star resort, although many visiting families often prefer to rent their own private villa as they usually provide much more personal space and have their own private facilities. There are also a large number of lodgings in the surrounding cities and towns.

This guide uses the following price ranges for a standard *double* room:

Budget	$
Mid-range	$
Splurge	$



Budget

- **AmeriSuites**, 8741 International Dr, 5895 Caravan Ct, ☎ +1 407 370-4720.

- **Baymont Inn & Suites Orlando**, 7531 Canada Ave, ☎ +1-407 226-9887. For the fourth consecutive year, Microtel Inns & Suites has been "Ranked Highest in Guest Satisfaction Among Economy/Budget Hotel Chains".
- **Rodeway Inn**, 6119 S Orange Blossom Trl, ☎ +1-407 545-6465. Free wireless high-speed Internet access and continental breakfast.
- **Suburban Extended Stay South**, 9435 Delegates Dr, ☎ +1-407 251-1110. Perfect for a long business trip or a family vacation.

Mid-range

- **Clarion Inn & Suites/Convention Center**, 9956 Hawaiian Ct, ☎ +1 407 351-5100. Walking distance from the Point Orlando and offers free wireless Internet access.
- **Comfort Suites Universal Studios Area**, 5617 Major Blvd, toll-free: +1-800-475-1694. Less than one mile from Universal Studios, free ground transportation to theme parks available.
- **Doubletree Castle**, 8629 International Dr. Designed as a medieval themed palace. 216 rooms and suites.
- **DoubleTree by Hilton Hotel at the Entrance to Universal Orlando**, 5780 Major Blvd, ☎ +1 407 351-1000, e-mail: stay@doubletreeorlando.com. Check-in: 4PM, check-out: 11AM. Located near Universal Orlando Resort, the hotel has 3 onsite restaurants, bars, swimming pool and fitness center. Also offering complimentary internet in rooms, business center, with 60,000 sq. ft. of meeting space.
- **Enclave Suites Resort**, 6165 Carrier Dr, toll-free: 1-800-457-0077, fax: 1 407-351-2001. 2 outdoor pools, kiddie pools, and hot tubs, tennis court, fitness center, indoor heated pool and hot tub. 2/2 suites w/ kitchens, sofa beds, and balcony.

- **Four Points by Sheraton Orlando Studio City**, 5905 International Dr, ☎ +1 407 351-2100. 301 rooms.
- **Hawthorn Suites**, 6435 Westwood Blvd, 8303 Palm Pkwy, ☎ 1 407 351-6600, 1407-597-5000">+1 407-597-5000.
- **Hilton Grand Vacations Suites at SeaWorld**, 6924 Grand Vacations Way (*off Central Florida Pkwy*), ☎ +1 407 239-0100. Check-in: 4PM, check-out: 10AM. Official Hotel Partner of SeaWorld. Studios with kitchenettes, one- and two-bedroom suites with full kitchens. 2 pools, activity center, fitness center, grills, free scheduled shuttle.
- **Hilton Grand Vacations Suites on International Drive**, 8122 Arrezzo Way (*at Vineland Ave*), ☎ +1 407 465-2600. Check-in: 4PM, check-out: 10AM. Studios with kitchenettes, one- and two- bedroom suites with full kitchens. 2 pools, activity center, fitness center, grills, meeting rooms.
- **Howard Johnson Plaza Hotel and Suites**, 9956 Hawaiian Ct, toll-free: +1-800-826-4847. A "AAA 3-Diamond" award winner, 223 rooms, high-speed Internet access, adjacent to Orlando's Orange County Convention Center.
- **Howard Johnson Tropical Palms Resort**, 4311 West Vine St. (W. 192), toll-free: 1-800-388-7698, fax: 1 407-358-5140, e-mail: reservations@hojotropicalpalms.com. 175 rooms, high-speed Internet access, close to all attractions in Orlando.
- **Hyatt Regency Orlando International**, 9300 Airport Blvd. Business facilities available, located within the terminal.
- **International Palms Resort**, 6515 International Dr, ☎ +1 407 351-3500.
- **JW Marriott Orlando, Grande Lakes**, 4040 Central Florida Pkwy, ☎ +1 407 206-2301. Luxury resort hotel with a spa and Greg Norman-designed golf course.

- **Marriott's Cypress Harbour**, 11251 Harbour Villa Rd, ☎ 1 407 238-1300, toll-free: 1-800-845-5279">+1-800-845-5279. In the heart of South Orlando, offering luxurious two bedroom, two bath villas near Sea World.
- **Marriott's Grande Vista Resort**, 5925 Avenida Vista, ☎ 1 407 238-7676, toll-free: 1-800-845-5279">+1-800-845-5279. One, two and three-bedroom villas with kitchens.
- **Nickelodeon Suites Resort**, 14500 Continental Gateway. In addition to the Nickelodeon colors and themes, two amazing pool complexes with water park features like slides, flumes and wet/dry play areas. Offers live Nickelodeon entertainment pool side.
- **Orlando Hotel & Convention Center**, 8978 International Dr, ☎ +1 407 352-1400. 244 two-room suites, 10 miles from Orlando Airport MCO.
- **Orlando Marriott Downtown**, 400 W Livingston St.
- **Orlando Vista Hotel**, 12490 Apopka Vineland Rd.
- **Parc Corniche Condominium Orlando Suite Hotel**, 6300 Parc Corniche Dr, ☎ 1 407 239-7100, toll-free: 1-800-446-2721">+1-800-446-2721, fax: +1 407 239-8501.
- **Parc Soleil Suites by Hilton Grand Vacations**, 11272 Desforges Ave (*off Palm Pkwy*), ☎ +1 407 465-4000. Check-in: 4PM, check-out: 10AM. Studios with kitchenettes, one- and two- bedroom suites with full kitchens. 2 pools, activity center, fitness center, playground, tennis court, meeting rooms.
- **Quality Suites Universal**, 7400 Canada Ave, ☎ 1 407 363-0332, fax: 1 407 352-2598. Check-in: 3PM, check-out: 11AM. $100.
- **Ramada Inn Orlando Hotel**, 6500 International Dr, ☎ 1 407-345-5340, toll-free: 1-800-272-6232">+1-800-272-6232. The only Ramada Hotel on International

Drive across Wet 'n Wild. King and double lakefront rooms, free breakfast, internet access and shuttle to attractions.

- **Reunion Resort and Club**, 7593 Gathering Dr, Reunion, ☎ +1 407 622-1000. Luxurious resort located 6 mi from Walt Disney World. Condos, villas, and private homes available. 3 championship golf courses, Waterpark with lazy river, ANNIKA Academy, dining, and personal concierge service.
- **Westgate Leisure Resort**, 6950 Villa de Costa Dr. Two bedroom villas w/ kitchens & washer/dryers; pools, fitness center; 1 mi from SeaWorld.
- **Westgate Palace**, 6145 Carrier Dr. Two bedroom suites w/kitchens & washer/dryers; within walking distance International Dr; pool, basketball, 1 mi from Universal Resort.
- **World Quest Resort**, 8849 WorldQuest Blvd, toll-free: +1-877-987-8378.

Splurge

In addition to the dozens of hotels on the Disney property, there are a few other luxury hotels and spas in the area:

- **Doubletree Resort Orlando**, 10100 International Dr.
- **Grand Bohemian Hotel**, 325 S Orange Ave. 250 rooms and suites.
- **Hard Rock Hotel**. The famous rock 'n roll themed hotel combines restaurants, clubs and shows to provide an entertaining place to stay.
- **Hyatt Regency Grand Cypress Orlando Hotel**, One Grand Cypress Blvd, ☎ +1 407 239-1234. Discover one of Orlando's most inviting escapes. Provides golf, tennis, pools, bikes, kayaks, boating, dining, & meeting facilities.
- **The Peabody Orlando Hotel**, 9801 International Dr. Luxury Orlando hotel, contemporary elegance, home to the famous Peabody Ducks and located across the

street from the Orange County Convention Center.

- **Ramada Coop Florida**, 8427 South Park Cir, toll-free: +1-866-700-4316.
- **Ritz Carlton & JW Marriott Grande Lakes**, 4040 Central Florida Pkwy. Two luxury hotels sharing a golf course, decadent spa, creative lazy river pool, and two restaurants.
- **Venturella Resort & Spa**, 8688 Palm Pkwy. Mediterranean/Tuscan theme, two restaurants, a spa, 7,000 square feet of meeting space.
- **The Woodhouse Day Spa**, 8060 Via Dellagio Way, ☎ +1 407-965-3131, e-mail: orlando@woodhousespas.com. 6,000 square feet of luxury and relaxation, located on restaurant row.
- **Wyndham Orlando Resort**, 8001 International Dr, ☎ 1 407 351-2420, toll-free: 1-877-999-3223">+1-877-999-3223. Check-in: 4PM, check-out: 11AM. Opened in October 2011.
- **Lake Eve Resort**, 12388 International Dr South Orlando Florida, ☎ 1 407 597-0370, toll-free: 1-866-999-5383">+1-866-999-5383, fax: +1 407-597-0371, e-mail: info@lakeeveresort.com. 176 all-suite accommodations equipped with full kitchens, washers and dryer included in every room.

How to stay safe in Orlando

Like most cities in America, there are certain areas of Orlando which are more dangerous than others. Some areas travelers should be cautious of are:

- *Parramore District*, area in downtown Orlando is a location where a lot of the area's homeless population congregates and crime rates are higher in this area.
- *Orange Blossom Trail*, north of Sand Lake Road is known to be a bit of an unofficial red light district. Drug and prostitution related crime is common here. Prostitution is not legal in Orlando, so you could spend a night in jail if you decide to indulge.
- *Pine Hills*, located around Silver Star Road and Pine Hills Road west of John Young Parkway. This is a lower income area that has struggled with high crime rates. The Greyhound bus station is in Pine Hills and is a place to use caution.

Extreme Temperatures

Never leave children, pets, or the elderly in a parked car for any length of time! Due to high temperature for most of the year, the interior of a parked car can easily heat to **lethal** temperatures in a short amount of time. During the summer, the interior of a parked car can reach 130-170°F (55-75°C) in just 15 minutes, regardless of the color of the exterior or interior, or whether the windows are open a small amount. You not only risk death, but **it is illegal and the consequences are taken VERY seriously,** including thousands in fines, potential imprisonment, and the involvement of the Florida Department of Children and Families.

While it is unlikely that any one individual would experience serious crime in these areas, tourists stand out in these areas, and can unwittingly do things that can make them targets for criminal behavior, so it is sensible to stay away.

While crime in the Orlando area is not particularly high, with the annual tourists far outnumbering the regional population (~2million), a substantial amount of local crime ends up being directed at tourists. The most common crimes are theft of items from cars

and hotels, so following common sense travel precautions are particularly important in an area like Orlando.

- Never leave valuable items in your car unattended, and get any purchased items to your hotel room as soon as possible. Consider utilizing the hotel room safe.
- Never leave small children unattended for any length of time, especially at a pool. Most hotel pools do not have lifeguards.
- Hotel room invasions do occur, especially open-air hotel and motel rooms when the victim leaves their hotel room unlocked and not dead-bolted. When you are in a hotel room, **always** lock your doors behind you, even if you expect someone in a minute or two.

While hurricanes attract most of the attention, the proximity to two coasts also brings frequent, and sometimes dangerous, thunderstorms. These occur nearly every day during the rainy season from mid-June through September. While some days it may only rain for 10 minutes, other thunderstorms can last for hours and its not unheard of for one location to remain dry while another spot 10 miles away gets a couple inches of rain on an afternoon. The summer thunderstorms are the main reason that Florida is the lightning capital of the western hemisphere. During these storms it is best to remain indoors due to the danger posed by frequent cloud-to-ground lightning. Golfers are especially vulnerable. A couple of dozen people are killed each year by lightning in Florida and many more spend much time receiving treatment for lightning strikes.

Pets are better off left with a friend or in a kennel. If you choose to bring your pet, note that most theme parks and hotels prohibit pets but may provide kennels for a fee. Most places to accommodate service animals, however. Also note above about interior temperatures in parked cars.

Where to go next after a trip in Orlando

Walt Disney World, about 35 minutes southwest of Orlando proper, is so expansive that it needs its own travel guide.

Also within an hour of downtown Orlando:

- Altamonte Springs.
- Celebration — the Disney-designed and -operated community.
- Kissimmee Large suburb close to Disney World.
- Winter Haven— About 30 miles south of Disney off US27. Home to Legoland Florida. [8]

A bit further, but good day trips or next destinations include:

- Cocoa Beach— Closest beach to Orlando it boasts world-famous surfing.
- Cape Canaveral— Home to the Kennedy Space Center and its large visitor's complex, which showcases many space-related artifacts (including some large rockets). While the space shuttle that once attracted tens of thousands of onlookers for lift-off no longer flies, there are occasional rocket launches throughout the year (schedule [9]).
- Daytona Beach— Home of NASCAR's famous Daytona 500 race, "Bike Week", and a popular beach.
- Canaveral National Seashore 24 miles of undeveloped shore; central Florida's only nude(in one spot) beach; 1000+ year old Indian relics; 58,000 acres for hiking, horseback riding, and biking; but no camping or concessions.
- Melbourne (Florida)/Melbourne Beach— Historic downtown and a great but "less touristy" beach than most on the Space Coast, beachfront camping nearby.

- New Smyrna Beach— Popular beach destination.
- Ocala National Forest— Great hiking and camping. Home to many fauna, including black bears and the Florida panther.
- Tampa and St. Petersburg— At the west end of I-4. Tampa is home to Busch Gardens Tampa Bay, the Florida State Fairgrounds and the famous Ybor City historic district. St. Petersburg hosts, among other things, Sunken Gardens and the Salvador Dalí Museum, and has its own well-known beaches.

Routes through Orlando

Tampa ← Lake Buena Vista ←	**W** I-4.svg **E**	→ Winter Park → **Daytona Beach**
Wildwood ← Winter Garden ←	**N** Florida's Turnpike shield.png **S**	→ Kissimmee → **West Palm Beach**
Punta Gorda/Tampa ← Kissimmee ←	**S/W** US 17.svg noframe **N/E**	→ Winter Park → **Jacksonville/Daytona Beach**